# Asad Ikram

MSc Data Analytics (Distinction), University of Portsmouth · Chevening Scholar 2024/25
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## PROFILE

Computational social scientist in training and data engineer working on online opinion: how people express views on platforms, and when machine-labelled text can be compared across media. I build LLM agents and labelling pipelines in Python and run them in production, and I have eight years of collecting and analysing large multilingual text (from 300+ freelance clients to companies in nine countries). I want to help map democratic belief systems from AI-led interviews in a way that holds across modes, languages and countries.

## WHAT THE POSITION ASKS FOR

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| Python and LLMs | Self-healing and builder LLM agents at M+C Saatchi Fluency (Claude with tools on a server I built, ground rules, approval gates); LLM labelling cascade at Artemis AI (own models, then DeepSeek, then Claude). |
| Text as data, NLP | Fine-tuned BERT on 250,000+ policy posts (MSc); BERTopic codebook with versioned, human-checked LLM tagging on 270,000+ mentions (Fluency); XLM-R, DistilBERT and DeBERTa classifiers (Artemis AI). |
| Belief systems, democratic attitudes | Dissertation on public reaction to UK economic policy; methods paper treating platforms as survey modes (measurement invariance, DIF, linking); Chevening proposal on evidence of public opinion for government. |
| Social media research | Ten platforms into reports for government communications teams (Fluency); 3 million+ Facebook and Instagram comments for creators and businesses (Artemis AI); online discussion across 15 markets in four languages (Dubizzle Labs). |
| Organisation, deadlines | CTO leading a team of five to a fixed beta date; client delivery across 300+ projects; led three engineers at Dubizzle Labs. |

## RESEARCH

**Ikram, A. and Haig, E.** "Is the Platform Part of the Measurement? A Protocol and Simulation Study for Cross-Platform Equivalence of Machine-Labelled Policy Sentiment." Preprint, arXiv:2610.16757 (2026), arxiv.org/abs/2610.16757. Treats each platform as a survey mode and applies generalizability theory, measurement invariance and differential item functioning, and score linking to machine-labelled text. I built the simulation: with known ground truth, pooling platform scores at face value gives the wrong sign of daily aggregate sentiment on roughly a quarter of days, from measurement differences alone. *No peer-reviewed publications to date.*

## EDUCATION

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| Sep 2024 - Sep 2025<br>awarded 8 Dec 2025 | **MSc Data Analytics, Distinction.** University of Portsmouth, United Kingdom. Chevening Scholar. Credit-weighted average 70.5/100; master's project 78/100. Supervisor: Dr Ella Haig. Modules included Big Data and Machine Learning, Intelligent Data and Text Analytics, Explainable AI and Data Management.<br>**Dissertation:** *Cross-Platform Sentiment Analysis of Public Reaction to UK Economic Policies.* About 279,000 public posts from X/Twitter, Reddit, YouTube and Quora, under university ethics approval (TETHIC-2025-111094). Fine-tuned BERT against BiLSTM and lexicon baselines; 200 posts hand-labelled; McNemar and bootstrap tests, chi-square tests across topics, Prophet forecasting. |
| Aug 2017 - Jan 2022 | **BS Computer Science.** National University of Computer and Emerging Sciences (FAST-NUCES), Pakistan.<br>Courses included Probability and Statistics, Linear Algebra, Calculus I and II, Numerical Methods, Design and Analysis of Algorithms, Database Systems and Applied Machine Learning. |

## EXPERIENCE

Dec 2024 - present
part-time, remote

**Data Engineer**, M+C Saatchi Fluency, London. Social media analysis for global brands including Amazon, Ford, Nike and Reckitt, and for UK government.

- Analyst on a twelve-month discourse study (100,845 Brandwatch and 170,542 Reddit mentions): BERTopic codebook, versioned LLM tagging.
- Social data collection, labelling and tagging, text and sentiment analysis with AI/ML, forum sourcing and pipeline architecture; a weekly pipeline of 2.2 million rows.
- Built a self-healing agent that diagnoses a broken forum crawler, regenerates it and tests it on live pages, and a builder agent that creates new crawlers, across a fleet of 64; secured with prompt fencing and approval gates, and I approve each merge.

2025 - present
part-time

**Co-Founder and Chief Technology Officer**, Artemis AI, United Kingdom. Social-media intelligence for creators and businesses.

- Processed 3 million+ Facebook and Instagram comments (111,000+ posts) on AWS: Meta Graph API collectors, an Apache Iceberg warehouse, and an LLM labelling cascade designed to escalate from our own NLP models to DeepSeek and then Claude.
- Building a 48-model system for the 15 December 2026 beta: comment toxicity, intent and topic classifiers tested on blind human-labelled sets; a storm detector for bursts of hostile comments; spam, bot, language and banter filters so dialect is not read as toxicity; community detection and match scoring on the network of pages; best-time, engagement-outlook and post-health models; image and video understanding (OCR, CLIP, Whisper); and Art-E, a retrieval-based advisor on Amazon Bedrock.
- Lead a team of five across models, AI/ML, deployment, app development and design; take part in pitching.

Feb 2022 - Aug 2024
full-time

**Associate Software Engineer, then Data Engineer, then Senior Data Engineer**, Dubizzle Labs (Dubizzle, Bayut, Zameen, OLX), Lahore. Promoted twice in about two and a half years.

- Data modelling and machine learning for competitor-intelligence dashboards: what people discussed, how much volume each site carried, and what worked on each platform and in which region.
- Designed the company's first web-scraping architecture on AWS: 15 markets, English, Arabic, Urdu and Hindi; led a team of three engineers in scraping and data warehousing. Owned a data-warehousing product end to end.

May 2023 - present
contract, remote

**Data Engineer (contract)**, Fix.com, Canada. OCR-based machine learning to parse parts catalogues from PDFs; models to backfill missing parts data; since June 2026, sole designer and operator of the crawler platform (about 10 million rows across 82 datasets).

2018 - 2026
remote

**Other data engineering work.** Lead Data Engineer, VendueTech, Ireland (2025: Azure-to-AWS migration, team of three); Data Engineer, Prefe, Milan (2024); CXG, Dubai (production crawlers, pytest QA); Metoda, Germany; web-scraping architecture for a US start-up and businesses in the Netherlands and Lithuania; earlier work for companies in India and Japan; freelance on Fiverr from 2018, starting during my BS: 300+ clients.

## SKILLS

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| Coding | Python (pandas, Scrapy, PyTorch, FastAPI, pytest), SQL, PySpark; Git, GitHub and CI. |
| Data and databases | Collection from APIs and the open web at scale; cleaning, deduplication, joins and validation; PostgreSQL, Redshift, Athena, DynamoDB, Apache Iceberg; AWS, Docker, Kubernetes. |
| Modelling and statistics | Hypothesis tests (McNemar, chi-square), bootstrap, Prophet forecasting; simulation with known ground truth; generalizability theory, measurement invariance and DIF, score linking; validating machine and LLM labels against human-labelled sets. |
| NLP and AI | Fine-tuning encoder classifiers (BERT, XLM-R, DistilBERT, DeBERTa-v3); LLM-assisted labelling (Claude, DeepSeek); OCR, CLIP and Whisper; BERTopic; LIME and integrated gradients; building AI agents; AI coding assistants (Claude Code, OpenAI Codex), where I write the specification and tests and decide what merges. |

## AWARDS, COMMUNITY AND LANGUAGES

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| Chevening | Chevening Scholar 2024/25 (UK Government's global scholarship, which funded the MSc), awarded for helping students and junior colleagues into freelance and remote careers and for a proposed cross-platform social media analytics system to give government evidence of public opinion. |
| Community | Author and maintainer of web-scraping-guide.com (since May 2026), a free public guide to web data collection. Helped university students start freelance careers and junior colleagues at Dubizzle into remote work; two of them got remote jobs. |
| Languages | Urdu (native); English (working language; MSc taught and assessed in English, IELTS 6.5). |

## REFEREES

**Dr Ella Haig**, Associate Professor in AI, School of Computing, University of Portsmouth. Ella.Haig@port.ac.uk. MSc dissertation supervisor and co-author.

**Dr Fahad Ahmad**, Senior Lecturer, Centre for Cybercrime and Economic Crime, University of Portsmouth. Fahad.Ahmad@port.ac.uk. Taught and assessed me on the MSc.